Ibrahim Bahjin-Shakirullah II

Dr. Ibrahim Bahjin-Shakirullah II (born February 14, 1952) is a Filipino cardiologist and one of the most significant claimants to the throne of the Sultanate of Sulu and North Borneo.

His followers recognize him by the title of **Paramount Sultan,** a distinction created to bring together the different royal houses of the Sulu Archipelago under one unified leadership.

What makes him stand out isn't just the royal lineage, though that part is remarkable on its own. He's a 17th-generation direct descendant of Sultan Shariful-Hashim, the very man who founded the Sultanate centuries ago.

What sets him apart is the combination: a trained heart specialist who spent decades at major Philippine medical institutions, and a traditional leader who has taken the Sulu Sultanate's territorial claims all the way to the United Nations.

He's from the House of Patikul, also known as the House of Bahjin or Shakirullah, one of three major branches of Sulu royalty alongside the House of Kiram and the House of Abirin.

His life is essentially two careers running in parallel: medicine and monarchy.

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Background and Early Life

Ibrahim Q. Bahjin was born on February 14, 1952, in Patikul, Sulu, a municipality in the southern Philippines with deep roots in Tausug culture and Sulu history.

He grew up as part of the Royal House of Patikul, a branch of the Sulu royal family that traces its origins directly to the Sultanate's founding lineage.

His 17th-generation descent from Sultan Shariful-Hashim, the founder of the Sulu Sultanate, places him squarely within the core of Sulu royal succession.

The House of Patikul, often called the House of Bahjin or Shakirullah, is one of the three primary branches of Sulu royalty, sitting alongside the House of Kiram and the House of Abirin.

Growing up with this kind of heritage meant carrying both privilege and responsibility from a young age.

Education

Bahjin was a consistent honor student and scholar during his school years in Sulu, and those early academic achievements opened the door to Manila.

In 1969, he enrolled at the University of the Philippines Diliman, one of the country's most prestigious state universities.

During his time at UP, he became a member of Tau Gamma Phi (Triskelions' Grand Fraternity), Batch '69, a brotherhood that would remain part of his identity for life.

He eventually pursued medicine, earning his Doctor of Medicine degree in 1978, with a specialization in Adult Cardiology.

It's worth noting: he made it from the southern tip of Sulu to one of the country's top universities, earned a medical degree, and specialized in a demanding field, all while carrying the weight of royal ancestry.

Professional Medical Career

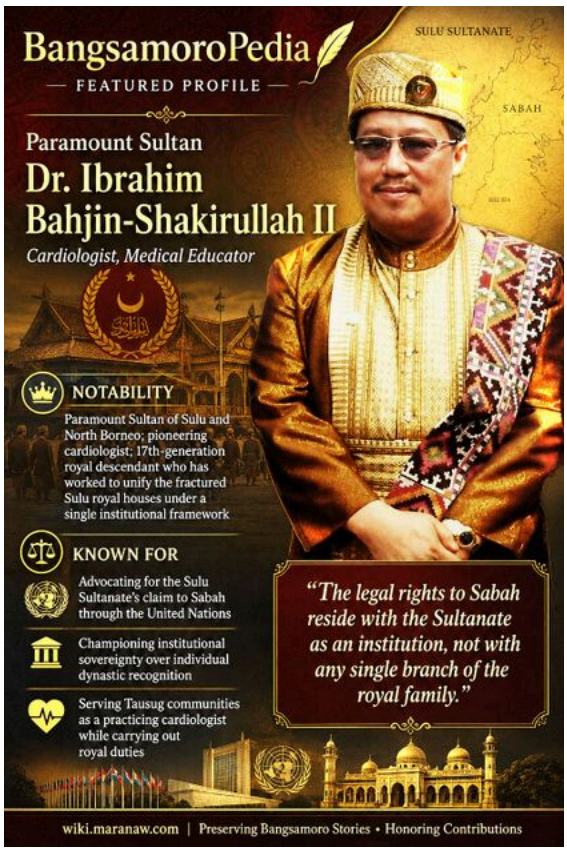
Dr. Bahjin built his medical career around cardiology, and he's done it across institutions and regions that reflect both his professional standing and his commitment to underserved communities.

Clinical Practice

He has served as a consultant at the Philippine Heart Center in Quezon City, one of the country's foremost institutions for cardiovascular medicine.

That's not a small credential. The Philippine Heart Center is a national referral institution, and serving there as a consultant puts him among the more recognized names in his field.

Dr. Ibrahim Bahjin-Shakirullah II



Born	February 14, 1952
Birthplace	Patikul, Sulu, Philippines
Nationality	Filipino
Ethnicity	Tausug
Royal Title	Paramount Sultan of Sulu and North Borneo
Royal House	House of Patikul (House of Bahjin / Shakirullah)
Lineage	17th-generation direct descendant of Sultan Shariful-Hashim
Profession	Cardiologist, Medical Educator
Specialization	Adult Cardiology
Degree Earned	Doctor of Medicine (1978)
University	University of the Philippines Diliman
Affiliation	Philippine Heart Center; Ateneo de Zamboanga University College of Medicine

Medical Education

Beyond patient care, he's contributed to training the next generation of Filipino physicians as a faculty member at the Ateneo de Zamboanga University College of Medicine.

Teaching at a medical school in Mindanao while maintaining a practice elsewhere reflects a deliberate choice to keep his work rooted in the region he represents.

Community Service

Much of his medical work is quietly oriented toward the people of Sulu and the broader Mindanao region.

He's known for maintaining a low profile in this area, focusing on providing specialized healthcare rather than publicizing his service.

In a region where access to cardiologists is limited, his presence matters in ways that go well beyond titles.

Installed as Paramount Sultan	2004
Fraternity	Tau Gamma Phi (Triskelions' Grand Fraternity), Batch '69
Key Advocacy	Sabah (North Borneo) territorial claim; Sultanate institutional sovereignty
Notability	
Paramount Sultan of Sulu and North Borneo; pioneering cardiologist; 17th-generation royal descendant who has worked to unify the fractured Sulu royal houses under a single institutional framework	
Known For	
Advocating for the Sulu Sultanate's claim to Sabah through the United Nations; championing institutional sovereignty over individual dynastic recognition; serving Tausug communities as a practicing cardiologist while carrying out royal duties	
Pull Quote	
"The legal rights to Sabah reside with the Sultanate as an institution, not with any single branch of the royal family."	

Institutional Contributions and Leadership

Installation as Paramount Sultan

In 2004, a council of royal datus and princesses elected and formally installed Dr. Bahjin as the **Paramount Sultan** of Sulu and North Borneo.

The position itself was created specifically to bridge the divide between the competing claimants from the different royal houses.

Rather than one branch declaring supremacy over another, the council's intent was to create a unifying figure, someone with the lineage, standing, and temperament to represent the Sultanate as a whole.

Royal Council of the Sulu Sultanate

He serves as a key signatory and leader within the Royal Council of the Sulu Sultanate, the body formed to give the Sultanate a unified voice on national and international matters.

The council's existence reflects a recognition among the royal families that fragmented claims weaken the Sultanate's position, both politically and historically.

Advocacy for Sabah

Dr. Bahjin is one of the most vocal advocates for the Sultanate's claim to Sabah (North Borneo).

His position is consistent and clearly articulated: the 1878 agreement between the Sultanate and the British North Borneo Company was a lease, not a transfer of sovereignty.

He has formally communicated this position to the United Nations, arguing that the legal rights to the territory reside with the Sultanate as an institution, not with any individual branch of the royal family.

That distinction matters. By framing the claim as institutional rather than personal, he attempts to remove it from the cycle of dynastic rivalry that has historically weakened the Sultanate's collective position on Sabah.

Cultural Significance and Values

Dr. Bahjin's approach to leadership reflects what he calls a "servant-leader" philosophy, with a deliberate focus on the preservation of Tausug heritage and Islamic values.

Where other claimants have sought recognition for themselves individually, he consistently pushes for the recognition of the Sultanate as a sovereign political and heritage institution.

He's also been a critic of the Philippine national government's handling of the Sultanate's role, arguing that Manila has repeatedly overlooked the Sultanate's historical significance and its potential contribution to regional stability.

He's called for the Sultanate's formal inclusion in peace processes and territorial negotiations, a position that some in government circles have found uncomfortable but others have acknowledged as historically grounded.

His framework isn't just about Sabah or about royal titles. It's about ensuring that the Bangsa Sug, the People of the Current, have a seat at the table when decisions about their land and their future are made.

Personal Life

Despite the weight of his royal title and the scope of his medical career, Dr. Bahjin is consistently described by those who know him as humble and grounded.

He resides and practices primarily in the Philippines, maintaining close ties with the Bangsa Sug communities he represents.

The contrast between his public role as Paramount Sultan and his quiet daily work as a physician is something those around him often point to as a defining feature of who he is.

He carries two identities that most people would find difficult to reconcile: traditional ruler and modern doctor. His life is an argument that those two things don't have to be in conflict.

Recognition

Dr. Bahjin's recognition comes from two distinct spheres.

In the medical world, his decades of service at the Philippine Heart Center and his faculty role at Ateneo de Zamboanga University College of Medicine reflect a career built on sustained professional credibility.

In the traditional political sphere, his 2004 installation as Paramount Sultan by a council of royal datus and princesses represents an institutional endorsement from within the Sulu royal community itself.

His formal communications to the United Nations on the Sabah question have also placed him on an international stage as a spokesperson for Sultanate sovereignty.

See Also

- Sultanate of Sulu
- Sabah sovereignty dispute
- Tausug people
- Philippine Heart Center
- Bangsamoro

References

- Biography provided by **Hannah Paiso-Bahjin (https://www.facebook.com/hannah.paiso)**

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